of uncontained emotion. The exterior walls dance with beguiling figures, very unlike the raja's other temples, and may have been due to the influence of Rani Kanakwati, the main patron. The raja had married many other women, including the sister of Raja Lakshmi Narayan of Cooch Behar, Abla Devi. (The Kachhwahas, however, did not recognize this marriage with a Bengali princess, so her son and descendants were always called rao sahib, never raja.) Man Singh sent Jagat Singh's young son, Maha Singh, to take over as Subedar of Bengal.

While the Padshah and the huge imperial army continued on their stately march towards the Deccan, Abu'l Fazl, who had remained in the south after Murad's death, and who had organized and stiffened the resolve of the troops under his command, began marching towards Ahmadnagar. Abu'l Fazl wanted to test the will of Chand Sultan and to see whether she might be willing to parley since, he wrote, 'though the boy [Bahadur] was considered as the ruler yet secretly that chaste lady was ruler'. The city of Ahmadnagar had been described a few years earlier by Faizi, during his diplomatic mission to the court of Burhan ul-Mulk. There was a stone fort outside the city, he had said, and there were open fields around. Water was provided to all the houses in the city via a canal which linked Ahmadnagar to a lake on the outskirts. The air was pleasant, he noted, but good melons not to be found…

> ..rather they were sour, and lacking in taste. Of all the fruits, the figs were not bad; grapes were there in abundance… Pineapples were imported in quantities from nearby and they were not bereft of good taste…roses were to be found only with difficulty, and… lacked in fragrance. On the other hand, champa and other Indian flowers were found in abundance. Sandal trees were seen there, as well as an abundance of white pepper.

The region was clearly rich in economic potential for the Mughals because Faizi also praised the excellence of the goldsmiths, weavers, and the high-quality cloth made in the Deccan.

But the fort of Ahmadnagar was a maelstrom of rivalry and suspicion. The Ethiopian Ahang Khan was camped outside the town, threatening Chand Sultan while, within the fort, she commanded the loyalty of only a few of the men. Golconda and Bijapur refused to join the fray and continued to remain resolutely neutral while the horizon grew dense with